Retrospace

User guide: run retrospectives, workshops and celebrations with your team

Retrospace is a live online board. One person (the **owner**) creates a board and shares a six-character **code**. Everyone else (the **guests**) joins with that code, needs no account, and takes part in real time from a laptop or a phone.

> **The idea in four steps**
> 1. The owner signs up and creates a board. 2. The owner sends the six-character code (and the passcode, if one is set). 3. Guests open the site, type the code and join as an anonymous name and avatar, or their own. 4. Everyone adds notes, the owner runs the session, and an owner-reviewed AI summary can wrap it up.

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1. Board types

Type	Use it for	What is special
Workshop	Brainstorms, planning, mapping ideas	A free canvas with sticky notes, text, shapes, connectors, frames and images. Starter templates.
Celebration	Birthdays, farewells, thank-yous	Cards for a recipient, GIFs, a reveal time, and a private reveal page the recipient opens.
Retro	Team retrospectives	Columns you choose, a guided seven-stage flow, voting, discussion topics, actions, optional anonymous notes and an AI summary.
Team wall	Ongoing appreciation	Shout-outs between teammates, reactions, birthdays and milestones. A feed or canvas view.

2. For the owner: set up

Create your account

1. Open the site and press **Get started**.
2. Enter your name, email and a password, then sign up. You land on **My boards**.

Create a board

1. Press **New board** and choose a type.
2. Pick a template. On a Retro board you also choose the **columns**: rename, reorder (arrows), remove or add as many as you like, and optionally press **Save template** to reuse them from *My templates*.
3. Set the title (a Celebration also asks for the recipient and occasion) and press **Create**.

Every board has its own unique code, and you can create as many boards as you want.

Share the board

- Open **Settings** (the gear icon) to see the **access code** and the link.
- Send the code or link to your team. Guests type the code on the home page.
- Optional: set a **passcode** (guests must enter it too), **lock** the board (view only), **close** it, or **revoke** the link.

> **Tip**
> Open the board once yourself before the session and add a few starter notes. Do your first run with a colleague on a second device, so you see what guests see.

3. For guests: joining

1. Open the site, type the six-character code in the **Join with code** box (capitals or lower case) and press **Join**.
2. If the owner set a passcode, enter it.

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3. Choose how you appear: stay **anonymous** with a generated name and avatar (press **Shuffle** for another), or type your own name and build your own avatar. Press **Join as ...**.
4. You are on the board. No account or app is needed.

> **Good to know**
> Your name and avatar are fixed once you have added something, so choose before you start. Use the same browser to come back as the same person.

4. Working on a board

The toolbar

Tool	What it does	Shortcut
Select (arrow)	Pick, move and resize items. Drag a box to select several.	V
Sticky note	Click the board, type, then click an empty spot to finish.	N
Text	Free text on the canvas.	T
Shapes	Rectangle, ellipse, diamond.	
Connector	Click one item, then another, to draw a line between them.	
Frame	A named area that groups what is inside it.	
Image	Add a picture, or on a card paste a GIF link or search Giphy.	

Everyday actions

- **Edit text:** double-click an item (double-tap on a phone). Finish with **Cmd/Ctrl + Enter** or by clicking an empty spot. **Esc** cancels.
- **Move and resize:** drag the item; drag a handle on its corner or side. Others see it move live.
- **Colour:** select a note or shape and pick a colour in the bar at the top.
- **Delete:** select the item and press **Delete**, or tap the red **trash** button in the bar at the top (this is how you delete on a phone).
- **Undo / redo:** the arrows in the top bar.
- **Zoom and move around:** the zoom buttons at the bottom right; drag the empty canvas to pan.
- You can only change your own notes. The board owner can change or delete anyone's.

Cards, GIFs and emoji

- **Add a card** (Celebration and Team wall): write a message, pick a colour, and add a GIF from the Giphy search or a pasted link.
- **Throw emoji:** the owner turns it on first (Settings, **Throw emoji**, **Allow throwing**). A row of emoji then appears at the bottom centre of the board. Tap one to get it ready, then click a note (or the board) to throw it; it flies for everyone to see. **Esc** cancels. Nothing is saved, and there is a short cool-down between throws. It does not work on a locked or closed board.
- **Shout-outs** on a Team wall: choose who it is for, write the message, and send. Everyone can react with an emoji.

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On a phone

- Tap an item to select it; double-tap to edit; use the trash button to delete.
- Pinch or use the zoom buttons. The tool bar sits at the bottom.
- As the owner, a laptop is more comfortable for running a Retro; a phone works well for guests.

5. Running a Retro

A Retro board walks the team through a staged flow. The owner moves between stages with the stage bar at the top (**Start**, **Next stage**, **Back**, and **+1 min** for the timer). Guests can only do what the current stage allows.

#	Stage	What happens	Guests can
1	Join	Welcome. People choose how they appear and wait for the owner to press Start.	Join, choose a name; not add notes yet
2	Collect feedback	Everyone adds notes to the columns, as themselves or anonymously.	Add notes
3	Group	The owner arranges notes into groups. AI can suggest themes (see part 7).	Watch
4	Vote	Each person has a limited number of votes (set when the board is created, default 3).	Vote on notes
5	Review and discuss	The most-voted notes become topics, discussed in order with a timer.	Watch and talk
6	Create actions	The owner records actions with an owner, due date and how you will know it worked.	Add actions (up to the limit)
7	Wrap up	Close the session. The AI summary can be generated here.	Read

- You can switch stages off, reorder them, and change the minutes under **Settings, Stages**.
- The stage and timer are shared: everybody sees the same clock.
- Votes: each guest gets the same number. Votes can be reset by the owner.

> **If guests see an empty board**
> The board is probably still in **Join**. Press **Start**, then move to **Collect feedback**. Guests can add notes only in that stage.

6. Anonymous notes

On Retro boards the owner chooses a mode in Settings: **optional** (each person decides with the *Post anonymously* switch), **always** (every guest note is anonymous) or **never**.

- An anonymous note shows an **Anonymous** badge. Its author is hidden from **everyone**, including the owner, on screen, in exports and in AI summaries.
- Only the author (and the board owner, for moderation) can change or delete it.
- Anonymous notes are not announced as selected on other people's screens.

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- Removing a participant does not remove their anonymous notes, because nobody can tell which they are.

7. AI summary and themes

AI is **off by default** and only the owner can switch it on. Notes are sent to Anthropic to write the summary, so the board owner must confirm a notice first.

Turn it on

1. Settings, **AI summaries**, switch on, then press **I understand**.

Make a summary

1. Open **Summary** (top bar) and press **Generate**. It takes a few seconds. You can also **Write manually**.
2. The result is a **draft that only you can see**. Read it on the **Report** tab and fix anything on the **Edit** tab, then press **Save changes**.
3. When you are happy, press **Share with everyone**. Guests only ever see a summary you have shared. **Make private** takes it back.

The report

- It shows section cards (what went well, what to improve, key takeaways) and two tables built from the board itself: **Most voted** and **Action items** (owner, due date, status).
- **Copy as table** pastes into Docs, Sheets or email. **Download PDF** and **Download image** save a clean white copy to share. The PDF is an image of the report; use Copy for selectable text.

Suggested themes

- In the Group stage, open **Themes** and ask for suggestions. The AI proposes groups; you can accept, rename, combine, split or ignore them. Nothing changes until you accept.

> **Always review**
> AI can miss things or phrase them badly. Treat the output as a first draft. Cost is a few cents at most per summary.

8. Owner tools

I want to	Do this
Remove a participant	Settings, **People**, **Remove**. Optionally tick “Also delete their notes”. They are locked out of the board.
Export the board	The download icon in the top bar: **PNG** image, **CSV** of all notes (with or without author names), or **Print / Save as PDF**.
Set a timer	The clock in the top bar: pick a duration, **+1 min** to extend. Everyone sees the same countdown.
Turn on voting	Settings, **Voting**: set votes per person and open or reset a round (Workshop boards; Retro uses the Vote stage).

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I want to	Do this
Allow emoji throwing	Settings, **Throw emoji**: turn on and choose the emoji list.
Stop new notes	**Lock** the board (view only) or **Close** it. Locked and closed boards cannot be edited by guests.
Cut off access	**Revoke** the link, or change the passcode.
Reuse a column setup	On the Columns step, **Save template**; choose it later from *My templates*.
Set a Celebration reveal	Settings, **Celebration**: choose the reveal time; send the recipient the **recipient link** (it ends in /reveal).

9. Troubleshooting

Problem	What to do
Guests see an empty board, or cannot add notes	On a Retro board, press **Start**, then **Next stage** to **Collect feedback**. Guests can add notes only there.
“This stage is closed for notes”	The Retro is past Collect. The owner can press **Back**.
“Choose a name first”	Reload the page and choose a name and avatar before adding anything.
I cannot edit someone else’s note	That is by design. Only the author and the board owner can change a note.
A text box I made disappeared	A text box left empty is removed when you click away. Type something before you finish.
Other people’s changes are slow or missing	Check your connection and reload. If it happens for everyone, the owner or host should check that realtime is connected (see the site’s /api/health page).
Wrong passcode	Attempts are limited. Wait a minute and try again, or ask the owner.
Giphy tiles are grey	Wait a few seconds, or paste a link ending in .gif instead.
AI says it is not available	The host has not set the AI key. You can still write a summary by hand.
I forgot my password	Password reset is not available yet. Create a new account for new boards, or ask the host for help.

Good luck with your session. Questions or requests: contact the Retrospace team.

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